

Bromine

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Br The third member of the halogen family, bromine is red-brown and is one of only two elements on the periodic table that are liquid at room temperature, the other being mercury. Toxic in nature, bromine must be handled with care. Its name comes from the Greek word *bromos* meaning “stench”—a reference to its unpleasant smell.



Medicinal salt

Potassium bromide was a key ingredient in the first effective medicines for epilepsy. It was used for human patients until the 1970s, and is still used by vets to control seizures in dogs.

White, salt-like crystals

Bromine purple

Tyrian purple is a naturally occurring dye secreted by some sea snails. It contains a bromine-based compound. In ancient Rome, this dye was highly prized, and purple clothing was seen as a sign of great wealth and importance.



Cloth dyed with Tyrian purple

Fresco at the Villa of the Mysteries in the ancient Roman city of Pompeii, Italy

Muride

Bromine was independently prepared by Carl Jacob Löwig in 1825 and Antoine Jérôme Balard in 1826. Balard extracted it from seawater and named it *muride*, from *muria*, the Latin word for brine. The French Academy of Science later proposed the name *brôme*, and in English “ine” was added for consistency with the other halogens.

Bromine vapor

A drop of liquid bromine formed at room temperature

Pure bromine stored in a glass sphere



Take a picture

Due to its light sensitivity, silver bromide is used in photography, since film coated with it darkens when exposed to light. This produces a “negative” image, where light areas are dark, and vice versa. This can then be developed into a photograph.



The image darkens on exposure to light.

The Dead Sea in the Middle East contains high quantities of bromine.

